

LSO 100 - Week 11

Humour, Satire, and Canadian Identity

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Week 11 Overview

This week, we delve into how Canadian authors use wit and satire to dismantle national myths and expose stereotypes. Our two primary texts bring very different – yet equally powerful – perspectives on Canadian identity, revealing that the "Canadian experience" is far from singular.

Roch Carrier's *The Hockey Sweater* uses gentle, nostalgic humour to explore the cultural and linguistic divide between English and French Canada. Through a young Quebec boy whose Canadiens jersey is replaced by a Maple Leafs sweater, Carrier shows how national symbols can exclude as much as they unite.

Thomas King's *One-Two-Three Little Indians* takes a sharper satirical edge, exposing how Indigenous peoples are stereotyped and mythologized by mainstream Canadian culture. His dark humour forces readers to confront whose stories are centred in the national narrative – and whose are erased.



Course Context: Why Literature Matters

Throughout this course, we have explored how literature helps us understand individuals, communities, and cultures. We have examined texts that challenge dominant narratives, question historical assumptions, and invite us to see familiar ideas from new perspectives.

Challenging Narratives

Literature questions who tells the story and whose voices are left out.

Historical Assumptions

Texts invite us to re-examine what we think we already know about the past.

New Perspectives

Reading widely expands our capacity for empathy and critical thinking.

This week we focus on two works that use humour in remarkably different yet equally powerful ways: Thomas King's *One-Two-Three Little Indians* and Roch Carrier's *The Hockey Sweater*.



Humour Beyond Laughter

When many people hear the word *humour*, they immediately think of laughter—stand-up comedians, funny television shows, or amusing stories shared among friends. While humour certainly entertains, literature often asks it to do much more.

→ **Expose Prejudice**

Humour can reveal biases that direct argument might miss entirely.

→ **Criticize Institutions**

Laughter at authority figures can question power without open confrontation.

→ **Reveal Uncomfortable Truths**

A reader may laugh at a situation only to realize the humour exposes something deeply troubling.

In these cases, **laughter becomes more than amusement—it becomes a way of thinking critically.**

Introducing Satire

Satire is a literary technique that uses humour, irony, exaggeration, and sometimes even absurdity to criticize people, behaviours, institutions, or social values. Rather than attacking directly, satirical writers invite readers to recognize contradictions for themselves.

A reader may laugh at a situation only to realize moments later that the humour reveals something deeply troubling. This delay between laughter and recognition is one of satire's most powerful effects.

📌 Satire lowers our defences. We may be willing to laugh before we are willing to confront uncomfortable realities.

Irony

Saying one thing while meaning another.

Exaggeration

Amplifying flaws until they become impossible to ignore.

Absurdity

Using the ridiculous to reveal the real.

Self-Reflection

Inviting audiences to examine their own assumptions.

A Tradition of Critical Humour in Canada

Canada is often associated with politeness, multiculturalism, and peaceful coexistence. Yet Canadian writers frequently challenge these national myths—asking difficult questions about colonialism, language, identity, race, regional differences, and belonging.



Colonialism

Writers interrogate the legacy of settler colonialism and its ongoing effects on Indigenous peoples.



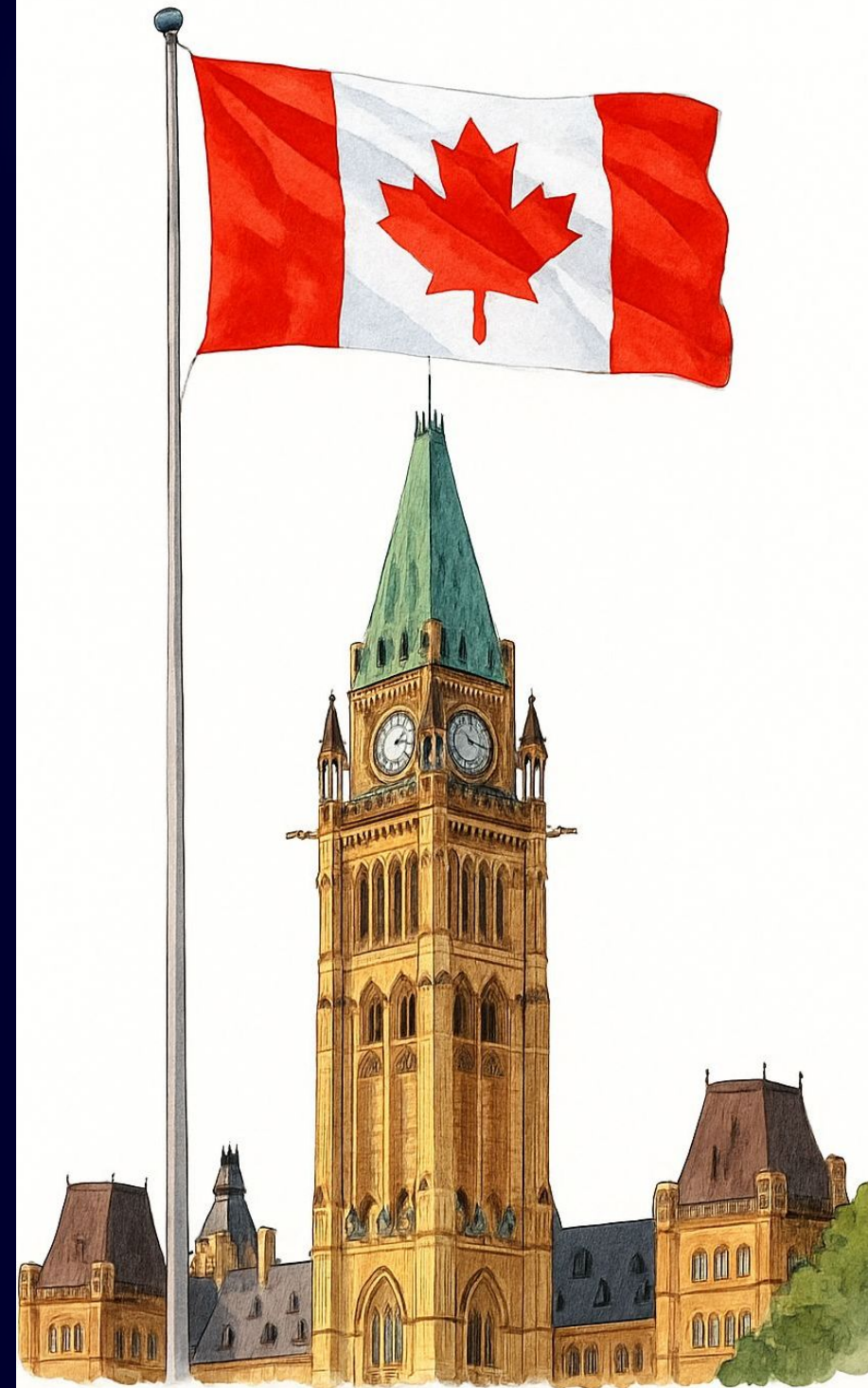
Language & Region

English–French tensions, regional identities, and immigrant experiences all complicate a singular "Canadian" voice.



Belonging

Who counts as truly Canadian? Literature refuses easy answers to this question.



What does it really mean to be Canadian?

This question does not have a single answer. Canada is a nation built upon multiple histories, languages, cultures, and perspectives. Any attempt to define one Canadian identity inevitably excludes someone else's experience.

Literature reminds us that **identity is constantly negotiated rather than permanently fixed.**

Hockey as a Canadian Symbol

The Icon

Hockey often functions as shorthand for Canadian culture worldwide. Images of frozen ponds, children skating outdoors, and cheering fans appear regularly in advertisements, tourism campaigns, and international media.

The Problem

Yet symbols are never neutral. They carry cultural meanings that extend far beyond the activity itself. A symbol celebrated by one community may feel exclusionary to another. Roch Carrier's *The Hockey Sweater* demonstrates this beautifully.



Roch Carrier's *The Hockey Sweater*

At first glance, the story appears wonderfully simple. A young boy desperately wants a Montreal Canadiens sweater like the one worn by his hockey hero, Maurice Richard. Through a misunderstanding, he receives a Toronto Maple Leafs sweater instead.

For readers unfamiliar with Canadian hockey culture, this mistake might seem insignificant. After all, it is only a sweater. Within the story, however, the sweater becomes something much larger than clothing.

Loyalty

Belonging

Identity

Community



The Power of Clothing and Belonging

The young narrator does not simply dislike the sweater because of its colour. He experiences it as a threat to his place within the social world he knows. This reaction may seem exaggerated—until we remember similar experiences from our own lives.

Think back to middle school. Imagine accidentally wearing the wrong sports jersey on spirit day, or arriving at a formal event dressed completely differently from everyone else. Even if no one says anything directly, you become painfully aware of your difference.

Clothing often communicates identity long before we introduce ourselves. Carrier uses childhood innocence to illustrate how communities establish powerful expectations about belonging—and what happens when those expectations are violated.



Beyond Hockey: Language, Power, and Quebec

Set in rural Quebec during the 1940s, *The Hockey Sweater* quietly reveals cultural tensions that extend far beyond the ice rink. The mistaken sweater symbolizes larger questions concerning language, power, and cultural identity within Canada.

English–French Tensions

The Eaton's catalogue—an English-Canadian institution—sends the "wrong" sweater, reflecting how English-speaking institutions historically overlooked French-Canadian culture and identity.

Carrier's Technique

Rather than delivering a political lecture, Carrier allows readers to experience these tensions through a child's perspective. Readers feel the emotional significance before they fully grasp its broader symbolic meaning.

Thomas King's *One-Two-Three Little Indians*



Rather than focusing on childhood memories, King uses satire to expose assumptions about Indigenous peoples that continue to shape Canadian society. Situations that initially appear ordinary gradually become increasingly uncomfortable.

King's humour often depends upon the expectations that readers themselves bring to the text. Many readers unconsciously expect literature involving Indigenous characters to follow familiar patterns—tragedy, spirituality, historical suffering, or cultural difference.

King deliberately plays with these expectations, challenging readers to examine how stereotypes influence perception.

King's Greatest Strength: Turning the Mirror Inward

Rather than telling readers directly that stereotypes are harmful, King creates situations in which readers begin noticing their own assumptions. The satire works because it **encourages self-reflection rather than accusation**.



Bring Stereotypes

Expose Assumption

Recognize Bias

This technique reflects one of satire's most important purposes. Satire does not merely criticize society; it encourages readers to examine their own participation within it. Sometimes we discover that the joke is not really about someone else—it is about us, our assumptions, and the stories we have inherited.

Stereotypes as Mental Shortcuts

Psychologists sometimes describe stereotypes as **mental shortcuts**. Our brains naturally organize information into categories because doing so helps us process large amounts of information quickly. While this ability can be useful, it creates significant problems when we assume that every individual within a category shares identical characteristics.

1

The Category

We hear that someone is an engineer, an Indigenous person, or a Quebecer.

2

The Shortcut

Our brains immediately attach assumptions about personality, interests, or behaviour.

3

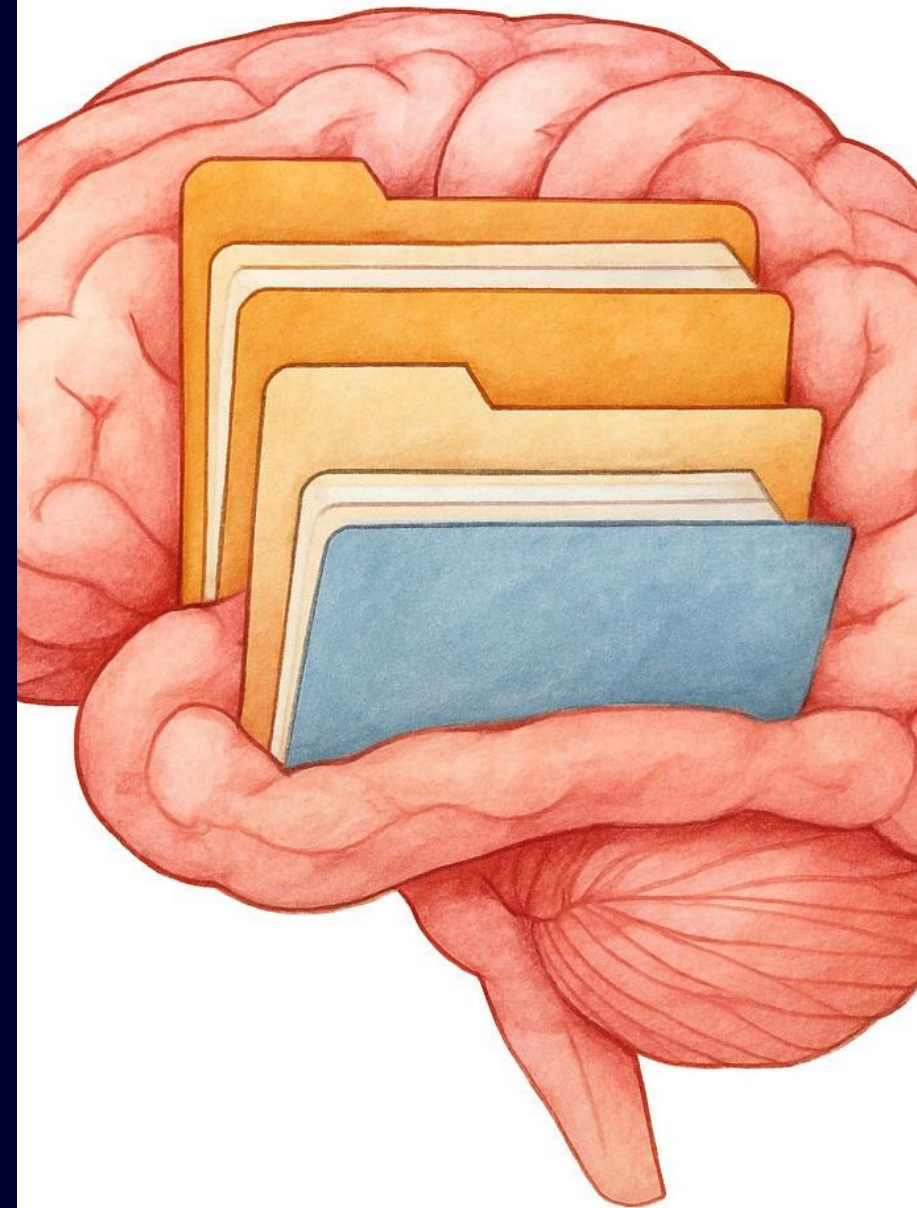
The Problem

Many of those assumptions will be incorrect—yet they shape how we treat that person.

4

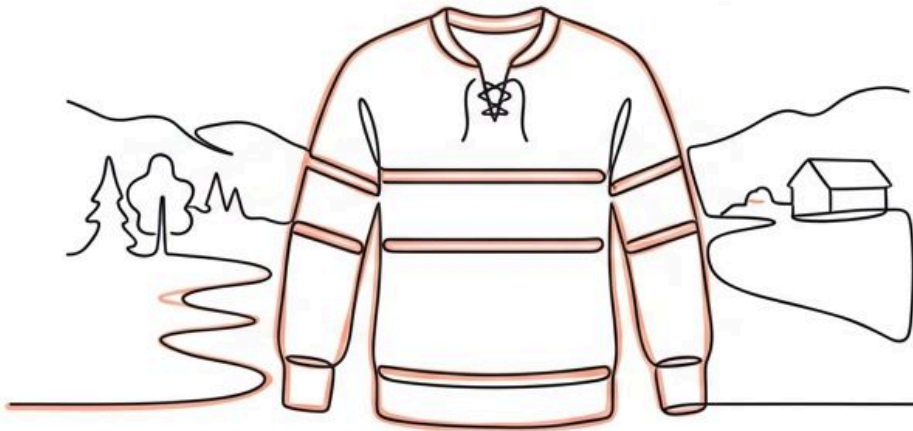
King's Response

Satire slows down this automatic process and invites readers to question it.



Comparing Carrier and King

When we place Carrier and King beside one another, an interesting pattern begins to emerge. Both writers explore identity through **ordinary experiences** rather than extraordinary events.



Carrier

Childhood lens, hockey sweater, rural Quebec, identity focus.



King

Everyday lens, contemporary satire, Indigenous-settler relations, self-reflection.

Neither author begins with grand political speeches or historical summaries. Both demonstrate that questions of identity often appear in surprisingly ordinary moments—and that is precisely what makes their writing so powerful.



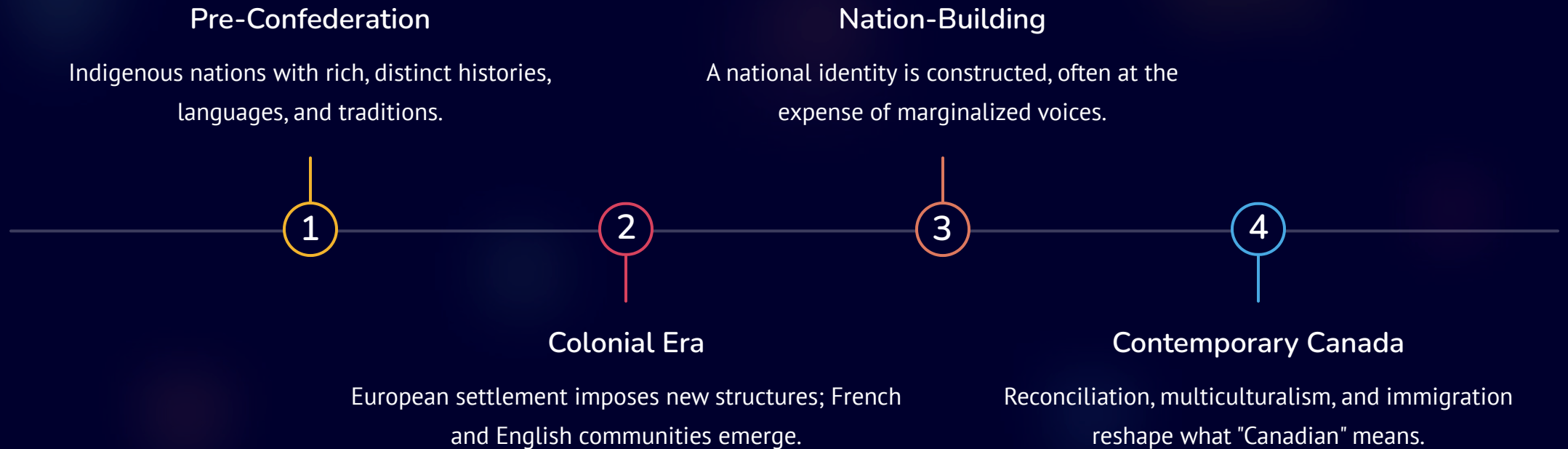
Culture Lives in Ordinary Moments

Culture is not experienced only through governments, constitutions, or national holidays. Culture also exists in childhood memories, casual conversations, family traditions, community rituals, and even the clothes we wear.

These seemingly ordinary moments often reveal the most important truths about who we are—and who we imagine ourselves to be. Literature's greatest strength is finding the profound within the everyday and making us pause long enough to notice it.

Identity Is Never Settled

Neither Carrier nor King presents Canadian identity as something complete or fixed. Both suggest that identity is continuously shaped by history, memory, relationships, and the stories a nation tells about itself.



Who Gets to Tell the Canadian Story?

We hear phrases such as *Canadian values* or *the Canadian experience*, yet these expressions can oversimplify a country that contains hundreds of cultures, languages, histories, and perspectives. Literature encourages us to resist these oversimplifications.

-  **The Story of European Settlement?**
Long the dominant narrative in Canadian classrooms and public memory.
-  **The Story of Indigenous Nations?**
Histories that long predate Confederation and continue into the present.
-  **The Story of Immigration?**
Millions of arrivals who have shaped and continue to reshape Canadian life.
-  **Quebec's Distinct Voice?**
A unique linguistic and cultural identity within a predominantly English country.

Or is Canadian identity created by bringing **all** of these stories together, even when they conflict?

Stories Are Never "Just Stories"

"Stories are never just stories." — Thomas King, *The Truth About Stories* (2003)

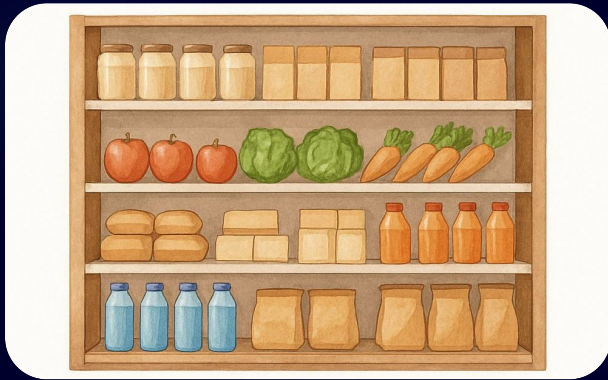
King has argued throughout his writing that stories shape how societies understand themselves and how they understand others. If a society repeatedly tells only one version of its history, alternative voices become marginalized or ignored.

Humour becomes one way of interrupting these dominant narratives. By making readers laugh, King creates an opportunity for reflection. **The laughter opens the door, but the ideas remain long after the joke has passed.**



Contemporary Examples: Humour on Canadian TV

Television programs use humour to explore questions of belonging, cultural misunderstanding, and identity—making difficult conversations accessible to broad audiences.



Kim's Convenience

Navigates Korean-Canadian family dynamics, immigration, and generational difference with warmth and wit.



North of North

Centres Inuit experience and northern life, challenging southern assumptions about Indigenous Canada.

Comedy allows audiences to discuss immigration, multiculturalism, religion, and family expectations without becoming immediately defensive.
Humour creates space for conversations that might otherwise feel uncomfortable.

Why Satire Persuades More Than Direct Criticism

Direct Criticism

Often causes audiences to become defensive because they feel personally attacked. The message triggers a protective reaction rather than genuine reflection.

Result: Resistance and dismissal.

Satire

Allows readers to arrive at conclusions themselves. Instead of saying, "Your assumptions are wrong," satire quietly asks, "Have you ever thought about why you believe that?"

Result: Self-reflection and lasting insight.

This invitation to self-reflection is often far more persuasive than direct argument. Satire respects the audience's intelligence while guiding them toward uncomfortable but important realizations.

Can Humour Ever Be Misunderstood?

Absolutely.

Humour depends heavily on context. A joke that one audience finds insightful may seem confusing or even offensive to another. Cultural knowledge plays an enormous role in determining whether humour succeeds.

The Hockey Sweater Without Context

Without knowing Maurice Richard's importance in French-Canadian culture during the 1940s and 1950s, the sweater's emotional intensity might initially seem exaggerated. Once readers understand that context, the sweater becomes a symbol of cultural pride and resistance to assimilation.

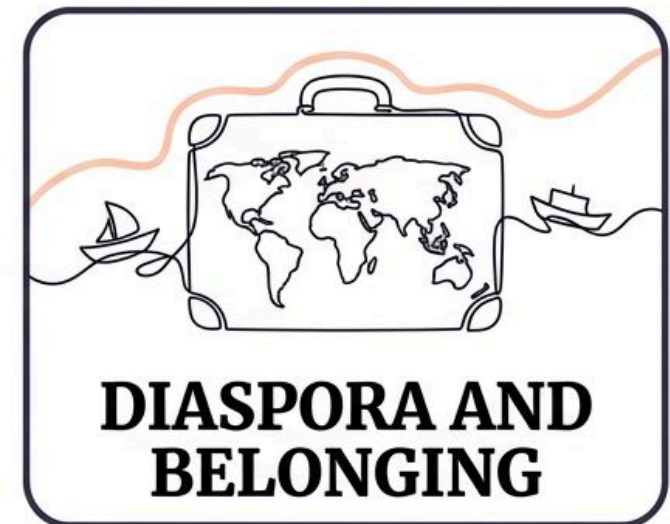
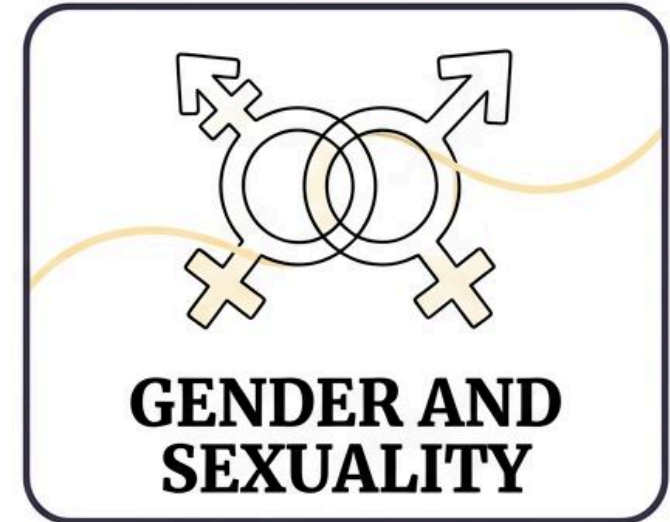
King's Satire Without History

King's humour depends upon readers recognizing stereotypes that have circulated in Canadian society for generations. Readers unfamiliar with these historical representations may initially miss some of the story's satirical force.

This reminds us that **literature is always read within cultural contexts**. The more we understand history, the richer our interpretation becomes.

Canadian Literature Continues to Evolve

This relationship between literature and history also explains why Canadian literature continues to change. Earlier generations often focused on survival in harsh landscapes or the challenges of nation-building. Contemporary writers increasingly explore new frontiers.



Canadian identity itself continues to change because Canada continues to change—and its literature reflects that ongoing transformation.

Literature as Civic Life

As readers, our role is not simply to identify literary devices or summarize plots. Our task is to think critically about how literature shapes public conversations.

Stories Shape Memory

Literature influences how people remember history and interpret the past.



Stories Define Communities

Shared narratives establish who belongs and what values a community holds.



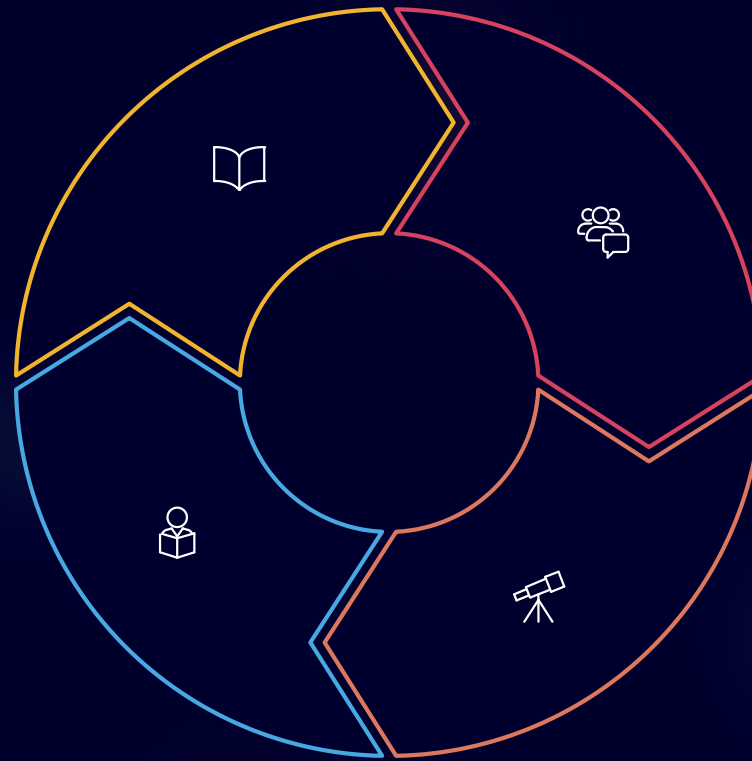
Readers Become Participants

Critical reading makes us active contributors to civic conversation, not passive consumers.



Stories Imagine the Future

Literature helps societies envision more just and inclusive possibilities.



Week 11 Key Takeaways

As we conclude this week, remember the core ideas these two works and our discussion have offered.

01

Humour Is More Than Entertainment

It exposes injustice, questions stereotypes, challenges authority, and invites readers to reconsider familiar assumptions.

02

Satire Encourages Self-Reflection

Both King and Carrier demonstrate that laughter and reflection work together—the joke opens the door; the idea stays behind.

03

Canadian Identity Is Plural

No single story can define Canada. Nations, like people, are defined not by one voice but by many.

04

Context Enriches Interpretation

The more we understand history, culture, and language, the richer and more nuanced our reading becomes.

05

Criticism Is Not Rejection

The strongest critiques come from writers who care deeply about their communities and hope they can become more just and inclusive.



The Question That Remains

When we laugh at a story, we should also ask ourselves: **What is this laughter asking me to see that I may have overlooked before?**

That question lies at the heart of both satire and literary study. It continues to shape our understanding of Canadian literature and Canadian identity—and it is the question we carry with us as we move forward in this course.

Next week, we will build on these ideas as we explore further dimensions of identity and belonging in Canadian writing.

References

The following sources were drawn upon in the preparation of this week's lesson materials. Students wishing to explore these topics further are encouraged to consult these works directly.

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